

Lesson 12: How to Receive Feedback

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OK, we've talked about mentors and coaches. Now let's talk about another key component of thriving in the workplace – how to receive feedback. If you have a coach or mentor in your corner specifically, you want to get as much feedback from them as possible.

Knowing how to receive feedback is a skill most people never master. It's something too many people never seek out to begin with – some people run from feedback altogether! But if you're going to thrive in your career, knowing how to be coachable, how to receive and implement feedback from your leader or peers is *essential*.

First, we're talking about *solicited* feedback, or feedback coming from a place you *trust*. We're not talking about barbs or criticisms made in the heat of an argument or anything on social media. Even if it's unexpected feedback from a colleague you otherwise trust, but who surprises you with the timing, if their heart is in the right place, it counts. Ask yourself, is this someone I like, trust or respect? If the answer to any of these three is yes, you want to be intentional about how you process the feedback.

I remember a time when the executive team I was a part of was tasked with providing peer-to-peer feedback in order to help us grow as a team. One by one, we each gave and received both positive feedback and areas for growth. I found providing positive feedback was easier for me than providing negative feedback. I tried to keep that in mind when it was my turn to receive feedback so that I could receive it in the constructive way it was intended. One key takeaway I received was that I need to be more inquisitive in meetings. That piece of feedback sticks with me to this day and helps to keep me mindful when participating in meetings.

You may get feedback on a regular basis at your job or you may not. Some people go their entire careers without getting feedback, or only get it once a year in their annual review. So here are a few tips.

The first step sounds obvious, but we need to *listen* to the person giving the feedback. Those who are practiced know how to accept feedback with grace. They don't fall apart. They don't lose their cool. Learn how to hold feedback with neutrality and open-mindedness in the moment in which you receive it.

Don't interrupt. Don't get defensive. Remember that feedback is often hard to give, and it might be your only chance to hear what they have to say.

The person giving the feedback might deliver it in an emotional or clunky way, and that's OK. They may have a string of faults and inconsistencies themselves, and that's OK – save

it for another time. You're not here to argue or talk about *their* shortcomings, you're here to get feedback on *you* and how you can grow.

Be mindful of your body language when receiving feedback. Are your arms crossed defensively? Are you scowling or slouching? Do you look afraid of what they're going to say?

Remember, you want to exude grace and poise, not defensiveness and hostility. We all know people who don't take feedback well, or who no one wants to approach on a particular subject. Don't let that person be you!

Next, you want to clarify the feedback. Repeat back to them what you heard them say, just to make sure that you're receiving the right message.

Thank them for their feedback. This person is trusting you with the maturity to be coachable and learn from whatever is being said.

Then you want to *process* the feedback. Here's a tip – feedback can often be hard to process in the moment. Sometimes it can take days or even weeks to fully sink in. That's OK! The point is that it sinks in, or whatever element of truth in the feedback can be received and help you to grow. Resist the urge to throw out feedback immediately if you don't think it's valid.

If you don't understand or aren't sure quite how to process something, reach out to a friend or mentor you trust. Tell them of the feedback you received and that you aren't sure what to make of it. This isn't to gossip or debate the feedback, but to get more clarity on how you can learn from it. It should be a mentor or someone you trust who can give you an honest opinion on what was said and how you can learn something productive.

Finally, you want seek out feedback on a regular basis. That's right – seek it out! Don't wait until your annual review once a year or for your leader to initiate the conversation. Ask for feedback on a regular basis. Not only from your leader, but also from other peers you trust.

You want to learn to ask for targeted feedback – rather than saying “Do you have any feedback for me?” try asking things like “Do you have any feedback on my communication style?” or “Do you have any feedback from me on my design elements?” You're more likely to get feedback on a particular subject if you invite someone to speak up in that specific area.

The truth is, how coachable you are – how well you receive feedback overall and can learn from it – goes a long way in how others perceive your professionalism and can even affect the rise and fall of your career.